



MONTHLY UPDATE

Rural digital data capture: monthly update, August 2026

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9 places. Every block below is carried verbatim from that place's own monthly update, where it was written, sourced and checked; nothing is written here.

BURUNDI · CHAD · ESWATINI · GUINEA · LESOTHO · MALI · NIGERIA · SIERRA LEONE · ZIMBABWE

Burundi

Civil registration is the one rural system with a number attached to it. Marking African Civil Registration Day, the territorial administration directorate [set out digitalisation of civil status in pilot communes and decentralisation down to zone level, with planned interoperability with health facilities for births and deaths notified through hill chiefs, and a UN agency stated that thirteen communes already hold a biometric registration system](#). Thirteen is the whole of the count: against well over a hundred communes, what the base records is a pilot that has been running for at least a quarter and a national position that has not moved.

Chad

[Solar-powered telemedicine kiosks](#) are helping rural patients overcome distance to care. No kiosk count, operator, consultation volume or funding source is on file.

Eswatini

Rural data collection got hardware rather than a system. The agriculture ministry [handed 40 tablets and 4 laptops, valued at E313,504, to agricultural extension officers on 10 August](#) under an IFAD and Green Climate Fund-backed project, for real-time crop, livestock and weather reporting by officers working with smallholder farmers across all four regions. No officer total, data platform, reporting standard or custodian for the collected field data is stated, so what the reports feed into is not on the record.

Guinea

The first rural digital service to reach farmers this month was a private one carried on a state bank's counters. An agritech firm and the state rural bank [launched a first cohort at Conakry on 6 August pairing field sensors, weather alerts and agronomic advice with the bank's network of over 1,000 service points](#). No cohort size, cost or coverage is stated, and the base still holds no state rural digital-services programme to set beside it.

Lesotho

Two movements reached rural service points from opposite directions. Thirty [SMS-based birth registration stations were established in government and church health facilities across Maseru, Berea and Leribe on 5 August](#), putting the capture point in the clinic rather than the registry office and on a text message rather than a terminal. Days earlier the universal service fund [opened procurement for Wi-Fi and network equipment at police stations across all ten districts](#).

Mali

The same week [recommended an updated universal-access strategy with a white-zone map, against a 2030 universal connectivity target](#). No map, coverage baseline or funding line accompanies the recommendation.

Nigeria

The communications minister told the President on 4 August that [deployment of about 3,700 towers begins around October](#), reaching more than 20 million people in communities with no telecoms service and with the capital stated as raised — no funding source, operator or contract is named. The baseline against which it is measured is [23% of rural communities connected to 57% urban](#).

Sierra Leone

The agriculture ministry is [finalising an upgraded interactive voice response platform, reported 98% complete, to give farmers direct access to ministry officials](#) under the national food-security agenda. Voice is the right channel for the users it names, and the account states no launch date, language coverage, call volume or cost — [98% complete](#) being the ministry's own description of a system nobody outside it has used.

Zimbabwe

The ICT minister told the National Assembly on 17 July that the universal services fund currently covers satellite-kit subscriptions only for digital centres and schools, and only for one year ([National Assembly account](#)).

Schools are where the terminals have gone. The education minister told the Senate that [11,500 satellite terminals have been distributed to schools — 8,000 to those with no wireless network and 3,500 to those already connected — with more than 1,300 institutions still to reach and a target of internet connectivity, solar power and national-grid access at every school by December 2026](#), alongside a cabinet commitment of 3% of GDP to research and innovation. The counts and the target are the minister's own; no school total, verification of installed and working terminals, or recurrent connectivity cost is stated — and the same fund that bought them pays a subscription for one year only.

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